AI product leadership · Applied AI · Multimodal systems

Denis Leonov

AI Product & Technical Lead

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Tbilisi, Georgia · Worldwide remote · Open to relocation · Employment / B2B

Lead AI products from user needs and strategy to launch and measurable outcomes. Combine **product direction, team leadership and hands-on engineering** across RecSys, generative AI and LLM agents. **8+ years** across software engineering, applied ML and technical leadership; teams up to **20**; AI adoption across **~15 departments/studios**.

+60%	+60%	-70%	20
Watch time	**Artists' workflow speed**	**Localization time**	**Peak team size**

Multimodal experience: Text · Images · Video · Audio / Voice · 3D

Core competencies

AI product leadership. User needs, strategy, market analysis, technical backlog, prototyping and launch.

People leadership. Teams up to 20; hiring, performance, staffing, resources and cross-team coordination.

AI architecture. RecSys, LLM/RAG, model training, backend, inference and automated retraining.

AI agents. MCP, orchestration, memory/context, persistent state, worktrees, handoffs and verification.

Product decisions. A/B tests, behavioral analytics, time-log comparisons and build-versus-buy evaluation.

International collaboration. English-language technical discussions, vendor evaluations, 20+ talks and mentorship.

Selected product & technical leadership

Short-video platform · NDA | Lead ML Engineer

Sep 2025 - Present

- **Independently launched a full recommender system in 4 months.** A/B results: **+60% watch time, +20 pp video completion** vs. baseline; recommended media duration doubled. Owned data, retrieval/ranking, training, inference and automated retraining. Snapshot: 54.6M events / 396K users / 3M items.
- Built **ClickHouse MCP and an analytics/dashboard agent** that became the foundation of the system used by company analysts; semantic search and bot/fraud detection. Advised engineers and introduced agent workflows for ML/backend development.

MY.GAMES | AI Architect & Lead ML Engineer

Mar 2023 - Dec 2024

- **Defined AI strategy with executives**; led a **5-person AI team** and adoption across **~15 departments/studios**, turning user needs into shared and studio-specific tools.
- Launched a Stable Diffusion product for **several hundred users**: **+60% artists' workflow speed**. Automated translation/localization: **-70% time**. Measured using multi-week time logs. Implemented custom style training, inpainting and ControlNet; built a RAG/LoRA assistant MVP.
- Led English-language discussions and evaluations with international teams, **Google Cloud, AWS, Layer AI and Scenario**; selected in-house solutions.

Phygitalism | CTO & Lead Data Scientist

Aug 2020 - Nov 2022

- Defined product strategy and developed Phygital+ from prototype to a **closed beta with the first few dozen users**; node-based platform with **30+ neural networks**.
- Led a **cross-functional team of up to 20**; hiring, performance, staffing and resources. Managed product and **B2B delivery from brief to client handover**; built ML/backend infrastructure.
- Led image/video/3D and generative AI R&D; introduced Scrum/ClickUp and trained **3 interns to Junior+ DS**.

Multimodal AI, grounded in actual work

Production: text, images, video and behavioral data - LLM analytics, Stable Diffusion, 4K deepfake and RecSys. **Audio R&D:** voice cloning, voice aging, TTS; Whisper/Piper voice MVP. **3D R&D:** generation experiments and Unity simulation.

AI agents as an engineering system

Designed **AIOS** for ML/MVP development: coordinator, specialist and verifier roles; isolated Git worktrees, task handoffs and shared context. Built MCP tools with versioned SQLite state, event logs, concurrency control, idempotency and session recovery. Role/Skill adapters for Claude Code, Codex and Cursor.

Independent AI products · MVP · 2026

Local-first personal AI system. Sole engineer: product requirements, Python backend, native macOS app, persistent memory, hybrid retrieval, local LLM and Whisper/Piper voice. Typed actions with validation, permissions and idempotency; background jobs with saved state.

AI mathematics tutor · Confidential. Sole engineer: architecture, backend/UI, photo/text input, hybrid RAG/reranking, versioned knowledge base and teaching guidebook, learner memory, personalized context, rules for missing sources and solution review.

Selected campaign & knowledge sharing

Deutsche Telekom - A Message from Ella. Credited ML Engineering Lead; full AI pipeline, facial aging and 4K deepfake, casting/production collaboration. Campaign: 2 Gold Lions, Webby 2024, 51M+ views.

20+ AI talks; technical guides, internal AI adoption and mentorship of engineers and early-career data scientists.

Further engineering & research experience

FunCorp | Senior AI Engineer · Apr - Jun 2025. LLM humor-generation R&D: paper review, training-data collection/generation and fine-tuning; reasoning models and MCP tool use.

JetBrains Research | Research Intern · NLP · Feb - Sep 2020. PPLM: replaced loops with vectorized tensor operations, improving execution speed by 70% over baseline. Adapted controlled generation to GPT-2 and real-time chat.

Saber Interactive · Gameplay Programmer · Apr - Sep 2019

Gazprom Neft · Data Analyst · Nov 2018 - Feb 2019

Self-driving car startup · Data Scientist & Unity Developer · Sep - Nov 2018

Nissan Manufacturing Rus · Python Developer · Jun 2017 - May 2018

Academic projects: transformer-based RecSys; vision encoder + GPT-2 captioning; transformer-based style transfer. PPLM chatbot.

Technical foundation

Python, SQL, PyTorch, FastAPI, Pydantic, AsyncIO · Transformers, Diffusers, vLLM, LoRA, RAG, MCP · Two-tower retrieval, learning-to-rank, CatBoost, DCN, FT-Transformer · ClickHouse, Qdrant, Dragonfly, S3, Docker, Kubernetes, CI/CD · Voice cloning, voice aging, TTS, Whisper, Piper, Unity

Education & languages

HSE University · MSc, 2022. Machine Learning and Data Analysis.

Peter the Great St. Petersburg Polytechnic University · Master's studies, 2018-2019. Machine Learning and Robotics; incomplete, no degree awarded.

Peter the Great St. Petersburg Polytechnic University · BSc, 2018. Applied Mathematics and Mechanics; thesis on a neural-network vehicle controller.

Russian - native · English - B2: technical discussions, international meetings and business correspondence.